

You said it...



to-do list, etc. with PIM, just like the Windows application that comes bundled with the phone with, say, MS Outlook. I have spent a lot of time and energy searching the Net for a solution but have not found anything useful. A few leads turned out to be so complicated that they were as good as useless. Is there some application that does this or is there any work going on in the Linux world to correct this? I use a Nokia Xpress Music 5130.

—Alok Chaturvedi, chaturvedi@nic.in

ED: It's wonderful to read about how you've migrated your whole office to Linux and that the whole set-up is working trouble free, without unnecessary downtime. Hope that other offices in your department also take note of this, eventually.

The Linux User Group of Delhi maintains a list of Linux-unfriendly Indian websites—titled Hall of Shame (<http://wiki.linux-delhi.org/cgi-bin/twiki/view/Main/HallofShame>), and I did notice that Bank of India has been listed since 2007.

As for connecting Nokia phones with Linux, we've already been contacted by a reader with a solution. We're yet to test it, and if it works, we'll hopefully publish the article in February.

Ubuntu 9.10: Good, bad, or ugly?



Kudos to your team for bundling the Ubuntu 9.10 CD with the December 09 issue. It's the best distro I've seen that works out of the box, including printer configuration. The only thing missing is multimedia codecs—but even that is working with the help of Google.

—Sundaresan Viswanathan, sundaresanv@in.com

ED: Thanks for your feedback. We're glad that it worked at your end. However, we have all read the horror stories of some Ubuntu 9.10 experiences online. Here is one from one of our readers...

Following Fedora making their successive releases 'unfriendlier' to ordinary home users, I changed to Ubuntu (7.04 onwards), and each release was a thrill as it installed perfectly and performed neatly. That is, until the 9.10 release, when the thrills were washed away. Compromises seem to have been made in 9.10 in order to show the achievement of targets (including major changes and the sacrosanct release date). I have been forced to go back to the good and faithful 9.04.

If Ubuntu wants to challenge Windows, it has to remember that the vast majority of PC users are simple home users for whom CLI and software jargon are hieroglyphics. The few applications that home users need—an office suite, Internet browsing, e-mail, a messenger, audio and video players/converters/editors, VoIP and Skype, simple games, social networking, Google

Earth, Picasa/Snappfish and the like—have to work readily and flawlessly from the GUI.

No video, awful audio, jerky display in Web browsers, sudden stalling or reverting to the log-in page, and a host of other problems in 9.10 have wrought the biggest havoc for home users. Even the workaround for video that's given in its release notes, does not work. The specifications of my PC, a Compaq Presario, SR1235IL (dated 2004), are:

- 1 Pentium-IV, 2.8GHz
- 2 2x512 MB (i.e., 1024MB)
- 3 Phoenix-Award 3.26 BIOS (dt.05/09/2005)
- 4 80 GB primary master Seagate and 160 GB primary slave Seagate make
- 5 Intel 82801DB-ICH4 with ALC658D sound card
- 6 Intel 82845G/GL(Brookdale-GJ/GE) chipset integrated graphics device

And here are the problems specific to Ubuntu 9.10 that I have noted so far:

1. Video playback does not work. As per release notes, it is due to the withdrawal of support to older video cards. The workaround for video given in the Ubuntu 9.10 Release Notes on the website, does not work. If a video file is clicked, the video player launches and immediately shuts on its own. In VLC alone, sometimes only the audio part plays.
2. Audio is of bad (harsh) quality and plays only directly when the mouse pointer rests on the audio file icon. There is no provision for user adjustments as in 9.04.
3. Sometimes there is a jerky display, including inside the office suite and in e-mail.
4. I've experienced sudden stalling, requiring a physical switch off and re-start.
5. The sudo update-grub command returns the message, "Command is not found".
6. The mouse pointer occasionally disappears, but the mouse continues to work without the pointer!
7. The printer configuration (Epson Stylus CX-2800) gives the colour component displacement in the print output. The same configuration works fine in 9.04 (i.e., with the driver of model CX-3800, as there is no driver for CX-2800 in Ubuntu).
8. Audacity does not work.
9. The display (including the mouse pointer) quivers or keeps running across the screen continuously if a .odp, .pps or .ppt file is opened. Sometimes the PC reverts to the log-in screen.
10. The Boot choice screen shows all the other operating systems available, but the PC does not boot by choice onto any OS other than Ubuntu 9.10.
11. The CPU is not powered OFF after shutdown. Adding `apm power_off=1` to the `/etc/modules` file does not